

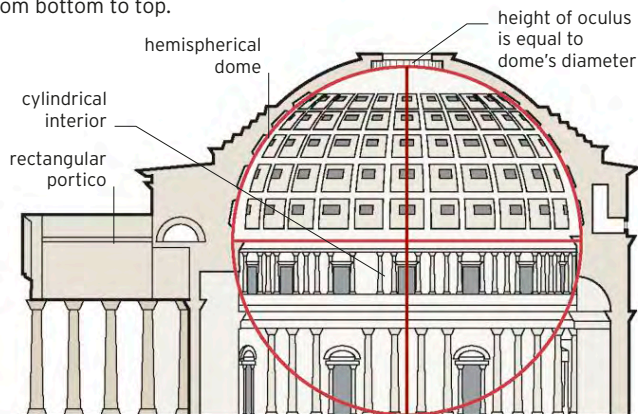


△ THE OCULUS

Natural light floods into the Pantheon through the oculus at the crown of the huge dome. Immediately below the oculus are rings of recessed panels, or coffers.

GEOMETRIC PERFECTION

The interior of the Pantheon is a cylinder capped by a roof that is half a sphere. The height of the cylinder is exactly equal to the radius of the dome, so a complete sphere could be inscribed inside the building. The coffers in the ceiling are arranged in five rows of 28, diminishing in size from bottom to top.



Column of Marcus Aurelius

A monumental celebration of the victories of Roman armies, illustrating ancient warfare in vivid detail

Standing in Piazza Colonna in the center of Rome, the towering Column of Marcus Aurelius was erected to honor the Roman emperor's military campaigns against "barbarian" peoples in central Europe from 172 to 175 CE. It was probably built between 176 and 193.

A tale of victory

Made of 28 blocks of Italian marble, the shaft of Marcus's column is 87 ft (26.5 m) tall. The column is hollow, with a 200-step spiral staircase rising inside. It was undoubtedly inspired by another famous monument in Rome, Trajan's Column, completed in 113 CE. Like the earlier column, it is covered in relief carvings, which unfold in a spiral from the foot of the column to the top. In the reliefs on the lower half, Marcus Aurelius is shown leading his troops in action against the Marcomanni, while the upper part illustrates his victories over the Sarmatians. One of the most famous scenes represents an incident in 172 CE when Roman troops, besieged by their enemies and dying of thirst, were rescued by a sudden rainstorm. The reliefs are of vital historical interest, providing detailed information on Roman military equipment and campaigning techniques, such as the building of pontoon bridges. Originally, statues of Emperor Marcus Aurelius and his wife Faustina stood on top of the column, but these disappeared in medieval times and were replaced by a statue of St. Paul in 1589.



◁ VICTORY COLUMN

Now topped by a Christian statue, the column was built to celebrate the victories of Roman armies on their imperial frontiers. The battle scenes in its reliefs are precise and graphic.